IN THE FOOTSTEPS OF THE GODS

***AMBLES ACROSS GODLAND* EXPLORES THE SACRED LANDSCAPES OF UTTARAKHAND IN MEDITATIVE WALKS, BUT LOKESH OHRI NEVER LETS HIS SCHOLARSHIP OVERWHELM THE NARRATIVE**

Ambles Across Godland by Lokesh Ohri is less a travelogue than a meditation on attention. The 440-page volume treats Uttarakhand's landscape as an archive of myth, memory and ecology. Ohri walks us from the Ganga to Kedarnath and Badrinath, from the Yamuna through the Dehradun valley into Kumaon, asking quietly: what makes a place sacred?

The book opens with the first hymn of the Isha Upanishad, framing it for readers, encouraging them to enter a contemplative journey. Uttarakhand still lives as a cultural ethos where rivers, ridges, shrines and village paths carry ancestral presence. The book makes you walk through stories one has heard and experience new ones.

Ohri draws on Hindu lore, oral tradition and field experience, yet his deep scholarship never overwhelms the narrative. As an anthropologist, historian, filmmaker and heritage activist based in Dehradun, he brings the patience of a researcher and the care of a conservationist. The prose is meditative but disciplined, turning knowledge into atmosphere rather than data.

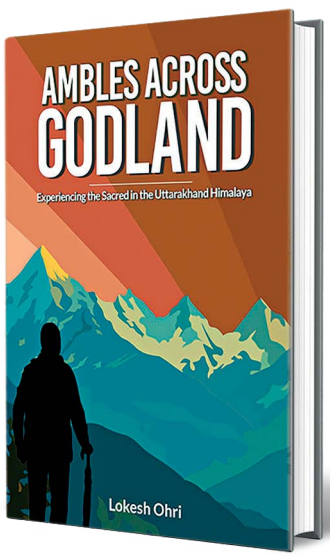
The book's core argument is about travel itself: consumption gives way to curiosity, curiosity to humility, humility to seeing. Ohri moves through sacred routes, lesser shrines and everyday practices that sustain belief, suggesting that true travel changes the seeker. The book's unhurried rhythm may frustrate readers seeking utility, but it returns attention to local lives and fragile ecosystems.

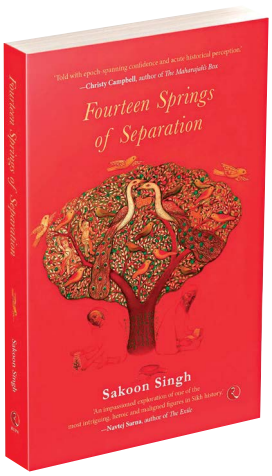
> OHRI VISITS SACRED ROUTES, LESSER SHRINES **AND EVERYDAY *PRACTICES THAT SUSTAIN BELIEF,*** SUGGESTING THAT TRUE TRAVEL CHANGES THE SEEKER

The limitation is political context. In 2026, the language of a sacred terrain carries ideological weight. Ohri's engagement with pilgrimage and civilisational memory reads as cultural preservation, yet may align with state narratives recasting landscapes through sacred belonging. Still, *Ambles Across Godland* enlarges our sense of sacred geography. For travellers, historians, students of religion and anthropology, and anyone who believes that walking attentively is also reading, Ohri offers Uttarakhand as a text of devotion, memory and meaning—one to be read with care and protected from the rashness of those who pollute its waters and soil. ■

—Shivani Bhardwaj

AMBLES ACROSS GODLAND
Experiencing the Sacred in the Uttarakhand Himalaya
By Lokesh Ohri
BOOK WORLD
₹999; 440 pages





FOURTEEN SPRINGS OF SEPARATION
By Sakoon Singh
RUPA
₹395; 352 pages

Duleep Singh) to William Dalrymple and Anita Anand's *Koh-i-Noor: The History of the World's Most Infamous Diamond* and Khushwant Singh's *Ranjit Singh: Maharaja of the Punjab*—most interestingly, she has drawn on the heroic songs of the *dhadi jathas*, ensembles of traditional balladeers who have penned many eulogies in praise of Jind Kaur.

In fact, it was a haunting musical rendition by a *dhadi jatha* about Jind Kaur's daring escape from Chunar Fort near Varanasi where the British had imprisoned her—which Singh chanced upon quite serendipitously one evening on YouTube—that convinced her to embark on this ambitious, historical novel. After escaping, Kaur journeyed on foot to Nepal to petition the Rana, who had been an ally of her husband, for protection. Her final meeting with her son, who she had last seen as a child, came after 'fourteen springs of separation', which is, of course, the title of the book. ■

—Amit Dixit